

Critical Perspectives on Human Sexuality & Society

Program: Socio-Cultural & Gender Studies Framework

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1. THEORETICAL FOUNDATION & EPISTEMOLOGICAL FRAMEWORK

The systematic examination of human sexuality within contemporary humanities and social sciences departs from biological determinism, recognizing sexual desires, identities, moralities, and relationship conventions as deeply cultural, historically contingent, and politically mediated phenomena. Rather than treating sexuality as an immutable biological drive, rigorous social inquiry analyzes how linguistic systems, legal architectures, and institutional powers categorize erotic experiences. In Western intellectual history, the transformation of intimate conduct into fixed identity categories reflects evolving regimes of knowledge and discipline.

By interrogating the discourses surrounding bodily autonomy, gender norms, and social scripts, researchers trace how normative categories establish criteria for belonging and deviance. Theoretical contributions from structuralism, post-structuralism, and queer theory illustrate that what cultures deem "natural" or "unnatural" represents a codified distribution of social authority. This curricular project investigates these shifting terrains through exhaustive readings and structured student assignments.

2. CURRICULUM MATRIX: WEEKS 1–2 (READINGS & APPLIED FIELDWORK)

READING 01: Foundational Discourse **Week 1**

Foucault, M. | *The History of Sexuality, Vol. 1: An Introduction* | Ch. 1 & 2 (pp. 15–49)

Examines the repressive hypothesis, the explosion of discourses around sexuality since the eighteenth century, and the institutional deployment of power-knowledge across church, clinic, and state apparatuses.

ASSIGNMENT 01: Discursive Field Mapping **Due: Week 1**

Deliverable: 1,500-word Critical Memo & Textual Deconstruction
Analyze a contemporary regulatory, medical, or media text addressing adolescent or public sexual health. Map how language constructs authority and define the implicit power-knowledge matrix operating within the document.

READING 02: Social Constructionism **Week 2**

Vance, C. S. | *Pleasure and Danger: Exploring Female Sexuality* | Ch. 1: "More Danger, More Pleasure"

Articulates the tension between vulnerability, legal risk, and autonomous erotic expression for women, framing sexual politics through intersectional socio-legal constraints.

ASSIGNMENT 02: Policy Dilemma Case Analysis **Due: Week 2**

Deliverable: 1,200-word Comparative Review & Annotated Chart
Select two municipal or university intimacy/safety policies. Evaluate how they negotiate the balance between protection against harm and the promotion of consensual individual agency and autonomy.

Through these foundational materials, researchers cultivate the analytical tools necessary to interrogate institutional claims of objective sexual standards, setting the stage for subsequent historical investigations.

Genealogies of Sexual Categorization

3. THE INVENTION OF PATHOLOGY AND THE MEDICAL GAZE

During the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, European and North American psychiatric institutions increasingly classified sexual practices that deviated from procreative marital frameworks as psychiatric pathologies. The transition from ecclesiastical condemnation (sin) to clinical diagnosis (deviance or perversion) transformed moral judgment into scientific taxonomy. Historians of medicine demonstrate how the diagnostic criteria for conditions such as hysteria, inversion, and paraphilias mirrored Victorian bourgeois anxieties regarding industrialization, gender roles, and demographic management.

The taxonomy of sexual variation served not only to pathologize non-normative individuals but also to delineate the boundaries of respectable citizenship. This medicalization facilitated state surveillance and intervention under the banner of public hygiene. Understanding this historical arc is paramount for deconstructing contemporary health rhetoric and legal frameworks governing bodily expression.

4. CURRICULUM MATRIX: WEEKS 3–4 (READINGS & APPLIED FIELDWORK)

READING 03: The Invention of HeterosexualityWeek 3 Katz, J. N. <i>The Invention of Heterosexuality</i> Ch. 2 & 3: "Medicalization and Early Norms" Demonstrates how "heterosexuality" emerged historically as a specialized psychiatric term before transforming into the assumed universal baseline of natural human attraction.	ASSIGNMENT 03: Historical LexiconDue: Week 3 Archival Audit Deliverable: Primary Source Primary Dossier & Etymological Timeline Examine late 19th-century medical journal entries or legal briefs. Trace the shifts in diagnostic vocabulary regarding romantic affection, documenting when terminology transitioned into popular vernacular.
READING 04: The Kinsey Paradigm & ContinuumWeek 4 Kinsey, A. et al. <i>Sexual Behavior in the Human Male & Female</i> Selected Excerpts on the Kinsey Scale Investigates empirical methodologies that challenged binary categorizations of desire, introducing quantitative scalar models to capture variance across diverse populations.	ASSIGNMENT 04: Survey MethodologyDue: Week 4 Evaluation Deliverable: 1,500-word Methodological Critique & Revised Survey Tool Critique Kinsey's sampling biases and interview protocols. Design an updated, non-stigmatizing quantitative questionnaire measuring modern multidimensional attractions and romantic self-identifications.

Students synthesize these readings to comprehend how historical taxonomies continue to inform legal entitlements, family law definitions, and therapeutic assumptions in the contemporary era.

Intersecting Systems: Race, Class, and Desire

Unit III: Critical Race Theory & Postcolonial Geographies

Modules: 5 & 6

5. DECENTERING THE WESTERN METRONORMATIVE PERSPECTIVE

The social organization of sexuality cannot be understood in isolation from racial capitalism, imperial conquests, and class hierarchies. Black feminist thought and subaltern studies illuminate how racialized bodies have historically been subjected to hypersexualization, labor exploitation, and disenfranchisement. The imposition of European heteronormative family structures frequently dismantled preexisting indigenous systems of gender and erotic plurality across the global South.

Contemporary scholarship emphasizes the concept of "metronormativity"—the assumption that authentic sexual liberation requires migration from rural or non-Western spaces to secular Western metropolitan centers. Dismantling this presumption allows researchers to appreciate diverse vernacular expressions of desire, kinship, and community survival that refuse Western categorical definitions.

6. CURRICULUM MATRIX: WEEKS 5–6 (READINGS & APPLIED FIELDWORK)

READING 05: Black Feminist Erotic Thought Week 5 Lorde, A. <i>Sister Outsider: Essays and Speeches</i> "Uses of the Erotic: The Erotic as Power" Reframes the erotic not merely as sensationalized sexual performance, but as a deeply rooted source of creative energy, inner validation, and resilience against systemic oppression.	ASSIGNMENT 05: Autoethnographic Synthesis Due: Week 5 Deliverable: 1,500-word Reflective Autoethnography on Erotic Power Reflect on Lorde's thesis regarding the suppression of feeling within hyper-rationalized systems. Formulate a personal or communal case study examining how creative joy counters structural alienation.
READING 06: Decolonial Queerness Week 6 Lugones, M. <i>Hypatia</i> "Heterosexuality and the Colonial / Modern Gender System" (Vol. 22) Theorizes how European colonization violently instituted binary gender roles and enforced nuclear patriarchal arrangements upon communal, non-binary indigenous civilizations.	ASSIGNMENT 06: Global Legal Comparative Dossier Due: Week 6 Deliverable: Comparative Legal Policy Matrix & 1,000-word Synthesis Select two postcolonial nation-states. Trace the legacy of British colonial penal codes (e.g., historical Section 377 statutes) and evaluate modern local grassroots strategies for decriminalization and human rights advocacy.

By challenging monolithic Western narratives, students develop cultural humility and analytical depth when examining intersectional expressions of identity across geopolitical boundaries.

Subversions, Technologies, and Embodiment

Unit IV: Performativity, Digital Spaces, & Biopolitics

Modules: 7 & 8

7. PERFORMATIVITY, ALGORITHMIC DESIRES, AND DIGITAL MEDIATION

Judith Butler’s theory of gender performativity disrupted the concept of an essential core identity, positing that gender and sexual roles are instituted through stylized, repetitive bodily acts. This framework underscores that bodily identities are not given by nature, but generated through sustained cultural repetition. Concurrently, the 21st century has witnessed an unprecedented migration of sexual sociality, dating, and identity formulation into digital spaces.

Geolocation algorithms, dating platforms, and content filtering systems now actively curate and discipline desires. Platform interfaces construct choice architectures that incentivize specific body aesthetics, commercialize intimacy, and categorize demographics according to commercial imperatives. As artificial intelligence and biometrics increasingly mediate human encounters, researchers confront novel iterations of surveillance, commodification, and relational connection.

8. CURRICULUM MATRIX: WEEKS 7–8 (READINGS & APPLIED FIELDWORK)

READING 07: Gender Performativity & Drag Week 7 Butler, J. <i>Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of Identity</i> Ch. 3: "Bodily Inscriptions" Examines how parodic repetition and subversive bodily practices reveal the imitative and constructed status of naturalized heteronormative gender arrangements.	ASSIGNMENT 07: Semiotic Media Analysis Due: Week 7 Deliverable: 1,500-word Semiotic Breakdown of Pop Culture Artifacts Select a viral media campaign, theatrical performance, or film. Analyze how clothing, voice modulation, and gesture enact or dismantle compulsory heteronormative codes.
READING 08: Algorithmic Intimacy & Platforms Week 8 Mowlaboccus, S. <i>Digital Sexualities: Social Relations and Digital Space</i> Ch. 4: "App Culture and Space" Analyzes how dating applications reshape urban geographies, bodily expectations, and sexual scripts, transforming serendipitous community spaces into data-driven digital exchanges.	ASSIGNMENT 08: UX & Algorithmic Architecture Audit Due: Week 8 Deliverable: Interface Design Teardown & Ethical Blueprint (1,200 words) Conduct an algorithmic and UI audit of an active dating application. Identify how filtering systems, monetization funnels, and badge identifiers privilege certain bodies while excluding marginalized users.

This intersection between classic queer theory and algorithmic sociology equips scholars to comprehend 21st-century transformations of courtship, identity creation, and bodily autonomy.

Community Resilience, Law, and Final Synthesis

9. PUBLIC HEALTH, MORAL PANICS, AND LEGAL CODIFICATION

The social trajectory of human sexuality is fundamentally bound to legal statutes and public health emergencies. From the AIDS epidemic of the 1980s to contemporary controversies regarding comprehensive sex education, reproductive technologies, and gender-affirming medical care, intimate choices reside at the center of legislative contention. Moral panics frequently utilize the rhetoric of collective protection to justify punitive censorship and discriminatory zoning practices.

Scholarly rigor requires parsing how empirical epidemiological science conflicts with ideologically motivated policy interventions. Grassroots mutual aid and community coalitions consistently emerge in response to institutional negligence, demonstrating the resilient capacities of marginalized sexual cultures to cultivate their own survival mechanisms, healthcare access, and political agency.

10. CURRICULUM MATRIX: WEEKS 9–10 & CAPSTONE REQUIREMENTS

READING 09: Moral Panics & Hierarchies Week 9 Rubin, G. <i>Pleasure and Danger</i> "Thinking Sex: Notes for a Radical Theory of the Politics of Sexuality" Introduces the "charmed circle" of sexual acceptability versus the outer limits of social condemnation, demonstrating how states arbitrate moral boundaries.	ASSIGNMENT 09: Legislative Discourse Policy Brief Due: Week 9 Deliverable: 1,500-word Legislative Brief on Contested Legislation Draft a policy brief analyzing a current municipal, state, or federal bill concerning sex education, bodily autonomy, or public performances. Detail stakeholder positions and civil rights impacts.
READING 10: Biopolitics, AIDS & Activism Week 10 Crimp, D. <i>AIDS: Cultural Analysis/Cultural Activism</i> "Mourning and Militancy" (MIT Press) Synthesizes grassroots direct action (ACT UP) with psychoanalytic grief, illustrating how medical crises mobilize collective political resistance against bureaucratic apathy.	ASSIGNMENT 10: Culminating Capstone Research Proposal Due: Week 10 Deliverable: 3,000-word Integrated Research Thesis & Ethics Protocol Formulate a comprehensive research design integrating at least five course authors, detailing primary archival or ethnographic methods, ethical considerations, and socio-legal implications.

MODULE	CORE THEORETICAL FOCUS	REQUIRED READING CHAPTER	APPLIED ASSIGNMENT TARGET
01 – 02	Discursive Regimes & Pleasure	Foucault (Ch. 1-2); Vance (Ch. 1)	Discourse Mapping & Policy Review
03 – 04	Medicalization & Scalar Variance	Katz (Ch. 2-3); Kinsey (Scale Excerpts)	Lexicon Audit & Survey Redesign
05 – 06	Intersectionality & Decoloniality	Lorde (Uses of Erotic); Lugones (Hypatia)	Autoethnography & Global Legal Dossier
07 – 08	Performativity & Platforms	Butler (Ch. 3); Mowlaboccus (Ch. 4)	Semiotic Analysis & App UI Audit
09 – 10	Moral Panics & Biopolitical Crisis	Rubin (Thinking Sex); Crimp (Militancy)	Legislative Brief & Capstone Thesis